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Title:

Exit Interview

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EXIT INTERVIEW
By Bridget Grace Sheaff

CHARACTERS:
NICOLE- Sharp, witty, very intelligent. Determined. Energetic. Very perceptive. Compassionate.
BRANDON- Clever. Wants to be the nice guy. Terrified of the idea that people might not like him. Hard-working. Would give you the shirt off his back.

> *(Note from the playwright: Both of these people are trying to make this an amicable parting. It's early in the breakup and real feelings are on the line, but both Nicole and Brandon want to walk away with as much dignity as possible. The things that are funny in the beginning should be allowed to be funny. The last things this needs is an air of defeat and defensiveness. Positive stakes. They still want what is best for the other person as well.*
>
> *(At rise, NICOLE, business attire, sits at a conference room table, binder and pen in hand. She reads over her documents, glancing up at the door and the clock every now and then. BRANDON enters, wearing a suit and carrying a box of desk contents. He sets it down on a chair and reaches to shake NICOLE'S hand.)*

NICOLE (*shaking his hand)*: Thank you for coming in today, Brandon. I know you are busy.
BRANDON: It's no trouble at all.
NICOLE: I wanted to ask you a few questions today about your decision. I thought it was important that we take some time, learn the reasons for your departure. We are disappointed to be losing you.
BRANDON: Yes, it wasn't an easy decision. But I think it's time I move on.
NICOLE: Sure. I hope you will be open and honest in this time, that you feel you can give complete answers.
BRANDON: Of course.
NICOLE: We're really looking to use the criticism and feedback here to drive some organizational improvements. Make some changes for the future. This process could be a learning experience for both of us, don't you think?
BRANDON: Agreed.
NICOLE: Well… Let's dive right into it. So you've been here, what, nine months?
BRANDON: Almost ten.
NICOLE: Ah. I suppose that depends on when you start counting from.
BRANDON: Sure.
NICOLE (*taking notes):* So. What caused you to start looking for something new at this time?
BRANDON: Like I said, I think I knew it was time to move on.
NICOLE: Of course…. do you care to expand on that?

BRANDON: Well, I think I looked at my life and my goals and I really asked myself where I wanted to be in five years, what kind of future I wanted, and it wasn't… here, ya know? I valued this position and I feel I learned a lot. I will always look fondly on my time here. It's time for, like you said, something new.
NICOLE: You want something different.
BRANDON: Exactly. (*NICOLE begins to write something down)* No, wait, no that's not it. This, um, this isn't a good fit anymore, ya know?
NICOLE: I see.
BRANDON: I don't know if I'm saying the right thing.
NICOLE: All you have to do is be honest. That's all.
BRANDON: Yes, of course.
NICOLE: That's all I've ever wanted from you.
BRANDON: I know that.
NICOLE: (*the facade cracking)* Don't just tell me what you think I want to hear. You can't be the nice guy all the time. You aren't the hero.
BRANDON: I wasn't… yeah, sure. Okay.
NICOLE (*recovering cheerfully)*: So. What did you dislike about the company?
BRANDON: So, suddenly, I don't like where this is going.
NICOLE: Honesty is important so we can improve our performance.
BRANDON: This doesn't sound like honesty, this sounds like masochism.
NICOLE: (*almost laughing)* Will you answer the question?
BRANDON: Mostly, it was great.
NICOLE: Yes. You mentioned that. Right now I'm trying to mine a little deeper, find out where we could have done better by you. Maybe get a sense of what you want, what you are looking for.
BRANDON: Well… there were times I didn't feel valued. Sometimes. I felt taken for granted.
NICOLE: (*this is a surprise)* Taken for granted?
BRANDON: You know, I felt like I sometimes wasn't part of major decisions. And there were times when I felt… like, stupid.
NICOLE: Like when?
BRANDON: When I would get things wrong or disagree with you or try to make choices or jokes or even when I would try new things, shake things up a bit, ya know. Or sometimes-
NICOLE: That sounds like you felt stupid a lot.
BRANDON: Well.
NICOLE: Well, no one can MAKE you feel stupid.
BRANDON: See, right there. It was stuff like that. When the responsibility for my problems was solely on me. If I was the one having the problem, then I was being overly sensitive or not taking initiative and it was never anyone else's fault. It made me feel… It was like my feelings and thoughts didn't matter to you.
NICOLE: Wow.
BRANDON: You asked me to be honest.
NICOLE: Did you share your concerns with anyone prior to deciding to leave?

BRANDON: … No, I didn't talk to you, but-
NICOLE: (*calm yet sarcastic)* Oh, interesting. I was about to say I don't *remember* hearing about this before. But, *now*, you want to talk?
BRANDON: I always wanted to talk, that wasn't-
NICOLE: If you didn't bring these problems to our attention, how could you have expected us to fix them?
BRANDON: That's what I'm saying. If I had talked to you about them, you wouldn't have really acknowledged them. It would have ended up being my fault.
NICOLE: How do you know that for sure?
BRANDON: I guess I don't.
NICOLE: And without being aware of it-
BRANDON: Look, I'm not saying I did the right thing by not talking to you about it. I'm saying that there was a reason and a logic to it at the time and when the reason no longer outweighed the problem, then I knew it was time to move on.
NICOLE: Did you share your concerns with anyone OUTSIDE the company prior to deciding to leave?
BRANDON: I don't want to answer that.
NICOLE: So you did.
BRANDON: I really don't-
NICOLE: Did you talk to Stacy?
BRANDON: I was looking for advice!
NICOLE: Who else? Charlie? Michael? Winston Churchill? Who knows all of this?
BRANDON: I didn't-
NICOLE: How many people did you talk to about this without talking to me?
BRANDON: A few, okay, but it's not the way you're making it out.
NICOLE: And probably your mother, right?
BRANDON: Well...
NICOLE: *(laughing sardonically)* Of course.
BRANDON: What does that mean?
NICOLE: You know what it means.
BRANDON: Look, it wasn't like I went around sharing private details about my time here. I wasn't telling secrets. I needed… I was looking for help.
NICOLE: No, you were looking for confirmation that you were right. You were looking for people to be on your side.
BRANDON: Doesn't everyone?
NICOLE: How could I have been on your side if you didn't talk to me?
BRANDON:... I don't know.

(*Pause.)*

NICOLE: I think we have gotten slightly off track.
BRANDON: I agree.
NICOLE: What does your new company offer that encouraged you to leave this position?
BRANDON: New company?

NICOLE: I assume you already have a new position. How long have you known you were moving on? And what is the name of your new company?
BRANDON: There's no new company.
NICOLE: Have you worked with them before? Am I familiar with them? And are they prettier than me?
BRANDON: There isn't anyone else.
NICOLE: I have trouble believing that.
BRANDON: It's not like that.
NICOLE: Then what is it like?
BRANDON: Nicole, I don't know what this is helping.
NICOLE: Was there a single event responsible for your decision to leave?
BRANDON: I don't think that's relevant.
NICOLE: Based on that response, I think it might be.
BRANDON: No, it wasn't one thing.
NICOLE: Are you sure?
BRANDON: Why would I lie about this?
NICOLE: There wasn't one conflict? Or one task? One request that might have pushed you over the line? What happened? What went wrong? Is there a way to fix it?
BRANDON: This whole line of questioning is meaningless.
NICOLE: Why have you decided to leave the company?
BRANDON: I already answered this.
NICOLE: Why have you decided to leave?
BRANDON: I told you!
NICOLE: I don't like that answer, try again.
BRANDON: Nicole, stop it.
NICOLE: Tell me WHY, Brandon.
BRANDON: I can't.
NICOLE: Yes. It's easy. Think words. Open mouth. Say them.
BRANDON: No… Not, "I can't tell you." I… I can't anymore, okay?

(Pause.)

NICOLE: I have a few more questions.
BRANDON: So do I.
NICOLE: That's not how this works.
BRANDON: Oh really? I think it's my turn to ask the questions.

(BRANDON grabs the binder from NICOLE and starts reading the questions aloud.)

BRANDON: "Number 16: Do you feel you had the resources and support necessary to be successful? If not, what was missing?"
NICOLE: (*reaching for the binder)* Brandon, give it back.
BRANDON: *(plowing through)*"Number 17: Did you have clear goals and know what was expected of you in your position?"
NICOLE: (*still fighting)* Knock it off. This isn't how this goes.

BRANDON: *(speaking over her)* "Number 22: What are the key qualities and skills we should seek in your replacement?!" Are you kidding me?!
NICOLE: I am the one asking the questions!
BRANDON: No, right now, it would appear I am the one asking the questions.
NICOLE: That's not fair.
BRANDON: Why?
NICOLE: Because I'm not the one who wants to leave!

(*Silence. BRANDON hands the binder back to her and sits again.)*

NICOLE: If there had been opportunity for promotion or advancement, would you have stayed?
BRANDON: Nicole…
NICOLE: Answer the question.
BRANDON: That wasn't how this was going to work. You never… it was clear from the beginning that I wasn't going to move up here. It took me a while to see that and to accept it, and once I did I knew that it was time to move on.
NICOLE: So for nine months…
BRANDON: Ten. Ten months. Depending on where you start counting. And no. Of course not. Not the whole time.
NICOLE: So what you are saying is that if I… if we had changed our minds…
BRANDON: If, if, if. Who knows?
NICOLE: Right.
BRANDON: But you didn't want that anyway.
NICOLE: You're probably right.

(*So much is unsaid in the silence that follows.)*

NICOLE: What did you value about your time here?
BRANDON: Lots of things.
NICOLE: Be specific.
BRANDON: Um, I always felt like I was cared for.
NICOLE: I thought you felt stupid.
BRANDON: I did. Sometimes. But it wasn't like it happened on purpose. And I still knew that you… I always liked when you would smile at me without saying anything and how you laughed at all my jokes, especially when they WERE stupid.
NICOLE: Hm.
BRANDON: I liked going on adventures. And learning new things. And being challenged. You were always challenging and exciting.
NICOLE: Yeah.
BRANDON: I valued your insight. Your passion. You were clever, charming. You stuck by your convictions.
NICOLE: A lot of past tense in that sentence.
BRANDON: You still are. And I still like it. I need to put it in past tense.
NICOLE: Yeah.

BRANDON: What did *you* value?
NICOLE: No.
BRANDON: Nicole… come on.
NICOLE: You... made me feel safe. And wanted. And smart. Not smarter than you or anything. I felt listened to. I liked that you listened to me.
BRANDON: Me too.
NICOLE: What would make you consider working for us again in the future?
(*Silence.)*
NICOLE: You know what, forget I asked.
BRANDON: Yeah.
NICOLE: Would you… recommend this to another person?
BRANDON: In a heartbeat.
NICOLE: Alright. I think that's all my questions.
BRANDON: No, it's not.
(*Silence.*)
BRANDON: I saw the list, Nicole. Go ahead. Ask.
NICOLE: I'm afraid of the answer.
BRANDON: I know.
NICOLE: If you already know, can't you tell me?
BRANDON: I think the answer might be less important than the question.
NICOLE: I haven't gotten any real answers this whole time.
BRANDON: Because you haven't been asking what you want to know. I can only answer what you ask me.
(*Pause.)*
BRANDON: Please ask.
NICOLE: Was it ever real?
BRANDON: Try again.
NICOLE: *(summoning strength*) Did you ever really love me?
BRANDON: Of course I did. Do. That's not what this is about.
NICOLE: How is it not about that?
BRANDON: Because I'm not the hero, Nicole. I can't *just* be the nice guy.
NICOLE: Right. Sure.
BRANDON: So. It's over.
NICOLE: *(a moment of pure desperation)* Help me understand why.
BRANDON: It's what needs to happen.
NICOLE: I don't get it.
BRANDON: Me neither. But these questions aren't going to make it any less hard.
NICOLE: I know.
BRANDON: You will be fine without me.
NICOLE: That is 100% not the point.
BRANDON: Yeah.
(BRANDON stands to leave, sliding the box towards NICOLE.)

BRANDON: I think it's all in there.
NICOLE: Thanks.

(BRANDON looks at NICOLE intensely for one moment. She doesn't look at him. He leans over to kiss her on the forehead and she pulls away. BRANDON retreats and exits. NICOLE sits, ruined but determined.)

END SCENE